

Telling Stories

The credit card companies epitomize “big business,” giving big business a bad name. They try to convince the world that Americans are spending recklessly and that is why the credit balances are out of control and so many are in need of debt cures. That is not the case. Most people today are using their credit cards to bridge the gap between paychecks. They are not buying expensive cars, lots of jewelry, and throwing fabulous parties like the celebrities we see on *Lifestyles of the Rich and Famous*. They are buying groceries, gas, and paying the dentist for their kid’s broken tooth.

Adam was getting by, check to check, working for a small company. Then the company went under, and Adam was out of a job. He was forced to cover his car payment, his rent, and other basic expenses using his credit cards. Adam found a job four weeks later, but in that short amount of time, he racked up almost \$5000 in credit card debt.

Peter has four kids and currently has \$100,000 in credit card debt. He can’t afford to pay rent and basic needs, let alone tuition. He has borrowed money from friends and struggles to pay back all his debts. Creditors are hounding him. All day long, Peter’s wife receives calls from credit card companies, collection agencies, and the landlord. They are constantly playing the shuffle game with their balances, shifting from credit card to credit card to try to minimize the fees and penalties. The financial stress is putting a severe strain on their marriage. The entire family is under extreme pressure day and night. Peter’s doctor has warned him that he could have a heart attack in the near future unless he reduces his stress.

Greg, a painter and handyman, was celebrating his recent engagement by going on a vacation with his bride-to-be. While he was away, he didn’t get the bill for his medical coverage and missed the payment. He unexpectedly had to undergo surgery for an emergency appendicitis, but his medical coverage had lapsed. Now Greg has an \$18,000 bill for the surgery and no means to pay it.

If you do not have a similar story, odds are that you immediately can think of someone you know who does.